

In their zeal to get started with the Five Whys, IGN neglected three important things:

1. To introduce Five Whys to an organization, it is necessary to hold Five Whys sessions as new problems come up. Since baggage issues are endemic, they naturally come up as part of the Five Whys analysis and you can take that opportunity to fix them incrementally. If they don't come up organically, maybe they're not as big as they seem.
2. Everyone who is connected to a problem needs to be at the Five Whys session. Many organizations face the temptation to save time by sparing busy people from the root cause analysis. This is a false economy, as IGN discovered the hard way.
3. At the beginning of each Five Whys session, take a few minutes to explain what the process is for and how it works for the benefit of those who are new to it. If possible, use an example of a successful Five Whys session from the past. If you're brand new, you can use my earlier example about the manager who doesn't believe in training. IGN learned that, whenever possible, it helps to use something that has personal meaning for the team.

After our meeting, the IGN leadership decided to give Five Whys another try. Following the advice laid out in this chapter, they appointed a Five Whys master named Tony Ford, a director of engineering. Tony was an entrepreneur who had come to IGN through an acquisition. He got his start with Internet technology, building websites about video games in the late 1990s. Eventually that led to an opportunity at a startup, TeamXbox, where he served as the lead software developer. TeamXbox was acquired by IGN Entertainment in 2003, and since that time Tony has been a technologist, leader of innovation, and proponent of agile and lean practices there.

Unfortunately, Tony started without picking a narrow problem area on which to focus. This led to early setbacks and frustration.